01

MEANING AND CHRONOLOGY - NEOLITHIC, NEOLITHIC-CHALCOLITHIC AND CHALCOLITHIC — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The safest chronology is regional and site-based rather than a subcontinent-wide start date.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Neolithic conventionally combines food production with ground, pecked and polished stone tools; many sites also show pottery and more sedentary settlement.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Memory hook: NEO is not one date; CHALCO is not only copper; CULTURE is not ethnicity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

INFERENCE: Labels are useful for comparison but must be applied after examining local sequences.

ANSWER LINE: **Chalcolithic denotes the use of copper alongside stone, not an exclusive copper technology.**

02

TRANSITION FROM FORAGING TO FOOD PRODUCTION - MOSAIC, NOT LADDER

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Transition is best understood as a changing portfolio of subsistence strategies.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Complex foraging and intensive use of wild plants could precede domestication.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Mixed subsistence is normal, not transitional failure.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: transition is best understood as a changing portfolio of subsistence strategies.

ANSWER LINE: **Sedentism and food production are related but not identical.**

03

WHY DOMESTICATION? COMPETING EXPLANATIONS AND A MULTI-CAUSAL VERDICT

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Environmental improvement can encourage domestication as much as crisis.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Environmental improvement can encourage domestication as much as crisis.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Social motives such as feasting, exchange, inheritance and territorial claims may have mattered but are hard to recover.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: archaeologists have proposed environmental stress, nuclear-zone knowledge, demographic pressure, positive feedback from productive domesticates...

ANSWER LINE: **Upinder Singh treats the impulses behind domestication as regionally variable and difficult to isolate.**

04

DOMESTICATION OF PLANTS - DIRECT EVIDENCE, INDIRECT EVIDENCE AND RICE CAUTION — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Cultivation is not identical to full domestication.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A crop package can combine local domestication, adoption and long-distance transfer.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Cultivation is not identical to full domestication.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Domestication is not identical to economic dominance.

ANSWER LINE: **Plant presence is not identical to cultivation.**

05

DOMESTICATION OF ANIMALS - HERD STRUCTURE, MORPHOLOGY AND HUMAN CONTROL — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

One small bone cannot establish domestication; assemblage pattern and secure identification are essential.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Mehrgarh shows declining wild gazelle and rising cattle, sheep and goat proportions through time.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Burzahom retained hunting and fishing while also using domestic cattle, sheep, goat and dog.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

One small bone cannot establish domestication; assemblage pattern and secure identification are essential.

ANSWER LINE: **Animal domestication is inferred from long-term morphological change, demographic profiles, geographic displacement, pathologies, residues and settlement context.**

06

POLISHED STONE, MICROLITHS, BONE TOOLS AND THE PERSISTENCE OF OLDER TECHNOLOGIES — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Polished Stone, Microliths, Bone Tools And The Persistence Of Older Technologies — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Polished Stone to Microliths, then testing the relationship through Bone Tools and The Persistence Of Older Technologies.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Tool choice depends on cost, repairability, raw materials and task suitability rather than a simple hierarchy of progress.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Bone and antler industries were especially prominent at Burzahom and Chirand.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: use technological persistence to challenge stage-based determinism.

ANSWER LINE: **Technology layers overlap; polished stone does not erase microliths, and copper does not erase stone.**

07

POTTERY, COOKING, STORAGE AND CERAMIC CHRONOLOGY — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Pottery supported cooking, serving and storage, but food production can precede pottery.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Ceramic seriation must be anchored by stratigraphy and absolute dates.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Treat pottery as technology, chronology and social communication, while refusing to equate style with ethnicity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Black-and-red ware is not one people or one date.

ANSWER LINE: **Pottery supported cooking, serving and storage, but food production can precede pottery.**

08

SETTLEMENT, HOUSES, STORAGE AND THE NEW TIME HORIZON

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

House size, internal divisions and settlement layout can suggest household differentiation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

House size, internal divisions and settlement layout can suggest household differentiation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Public works require coordination but do not by themselves prove a state.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Sedentism concentrates waste, pathogens and social tensions while also enabling craft and community institutions.

ANSWER LINE: **Explain settlement as a package of permanence, storage, property, public labour, health risk and social negotiation.**

09

SUBSISTENCE, LABOUR, HEALTH AND DEMOGRAPHIC CONSEQUENCES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Subsistence, Labour, Health And Demographic Consequences is analysed by relating Subsistence to Labour, then testing the relationship through Health and Demographic Consequences.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Food production increased carrying capacity but could distribute benefits unequally.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

More food does not guarantee better nutrition.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: population growth can be an outcome as well as a pressure.

ANSWER LINE: **Farming could raise aggregate food availability and support population growth, but early farmers often faced narrower diets, infectious disease, hard labour and vulnerability to drought, pests and storage loss.**

10

CRAFTS, SPECIALIZATION AND EXCHANGE NETWORKS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Crafts, Specialization And Exchange Networks is analysed by relating Crafts to Specialization, then testing the relationship through Exchange Networks and Mains angle.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use exchange to connect ecology with society: specialized zones traded complementary resources without necessarily forming one political system.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Early villages were not isolated subsistence units.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Imported material does not prove political control.

ANSWER LINE: **Exchange can move raw materials, finished goods, people and ideas.**

11

SOCIAL DIFFERENTIATION, HOUSEHOLD ORGANIZATION AND SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Inamgaon has interpreted craft quarters, central elite structures and a settlement hierarchy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Inamgaon has interpreted craft quarters, central elite structures and a settlement hierarchy.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Differences in house size, settlement position, diet, burial treatment, stored wealth and craft location suggest emerging ranks at some sites, but inequality varied greatly and should not be read as a fully developed class state.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Use the phrase 'suggests ranked differentiation' rather than claiming kingship unless evidence is stronger.

ANSWER LINE: **Settlement hierarchy does not automatically equal state hierarchy.**

12

RITUAL, BURIALS, FIGURINES AND THE PROBLEM OF MEANING

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Malwa and Jorwe contexts include fire installations, figurines and house-floor burials.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Malwa and Jorwe contexts include fire installations, figurines and house-floor burials.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Inamgaon has unusual urn and symbolic burials as well as temporary clay figurines.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: burzahom has human and animal burials and a hunting engraving.

ANSWER LINE: **Ritual is inferred from patterned, non-utilitarian context.**

13

REGIONAL MAP IN TEXT - THE INDIAN NEOLITHIC MOSAIC — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Study link: Dedicated regional cases follow.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Similar tools may reflect convergent adaptation, interaction or shared learning; the mechanism must be tested.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

North-west is not the only early agricultural zone.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: study link: Dedicated regional cases follow.

ANSWER LINE: **South Indian ash mounds are not universal even within the south.**

14

NORTH-WEST NEOLITHIC - MEHRGARH AS A LONG SEQUENCE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Mehrgarh demonstrates that early village formation was already socially and economically complex.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Mehrgarh demonstrates that early village formation was already socially and economically complex.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Mehrgarh was not a city in its earliest phases.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The 2025 radiocarbon revision must be presented alongside, not silently substituted for, older textbook chronology.

ANSWER LINE: **Use Mehrgarh as a sequence, not a label: subsistence, storage, craft, burial and exchange changed across periods.**

15

KASHMIR NEOLITHIC - BURZAHOM AND GUFKRAL — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Burzahom is not famous for rock-cut shrines.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Burzahom Period I is known for round or oval pits, storage pits and ground-level hearths.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Burzahom is not famous for rock-cut shrines.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

DEBATE: Pits may have been dwellings, storage units or seasonally used structures; majority opinion is not proof.

ANSWER LINE: **Burzahom and Gufkral show pit structures, polished stone and bone tools, hunting and fishing, increasing cultivation and herding, distinctive burials and contacts beyond the valley.**

16

VINDHYAN FRINGES AND MIDDLE GANGA - KOLDIHWA, MAHAGARA AND LAHURADEWA — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Lahuradewa later developed many earthen silos and wider crop-animal packages.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Lahuradewa later developed many earthen silos and wider crop-animal packages.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

These sites are central to debates on rice, cattle, continuity from the Mesolithic and the emergence of settled food-producing communities outside the north-west.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: the regional Neolithic emerged from an established Mesolithic background and retained microliths.

ANSWER LINE: **Use the middle Ganga evidence to argue for regional experimentation while remaining cautious about claims of independent domestication.**

17

EASTERN INDIA - REPRESENTATIVE SEQUENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Other eastern sites show regional spread, but do not memorise an exhaustive inventory unless a specific option requires it.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Other eastern sites show regional spread, but do not memorise an exhaustive inventory unless a specific option requires it.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that other eastern sites show regional spread.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: other eastern sites show regional spread.

ANSWER LINE: **Chirand is the core exam anchor: a Bihar site with a long Neolithic-Chalcolithic sequence and bone-tool evidence.**

18

NORTH-EAST NEOLITHIC - REGIONAL CAUTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, North-East Neolithic - Regional Caution is analysed by relating North-east evidence to North-east, then testing the relationship through India and India.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use it to reject an all-India sequence; do not turn corridor or extension hypotheses into settled site chronologies without a verified source.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that north-east evidence is regionally important but uneven.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: north-east evidence is regionally important but uneven.

ANSWER LINE: **North-east evidence is regionally important but uneven.**

19

SOUTH INDIAN NEOLITHIC - CHRONOLOGY, LANDSCAPE AND REGIONAL SEQUENCE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

South Indian Neolithic was not a copy of Mehrgarh.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The link between Mesolithic and Neolithic phases in the far south remains incompletely worked out.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Ash mounds are regional, not universal.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Cattle were central, but recent botanical work demonstrates important millet and pulse cultivation.

ANSWER LINE: **South Indian Neolithic was not a copy of Mehrgarh.**

20

ASH MOUNDS - FORMATION, FUNCTION AND COMPETING INTERPRETATIONS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Ash Mounds - Formation, Function And Competing Interpretations — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating Ash Mounds - Formation to Function, then testing the relationship through Competing Interpretations and Mains angle.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Present the debate as a hierarchy of confidence: dung origin is strong; exact function and symbolism remain variable.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Dung origin does not settle social meaning.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: utnur had pen enclosures and cattle hoof impressions.

ANSWER LINE: **Do not force one function on the entire class of sites.**

21

SOUTH INDIAN CASE RECALL

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Retain one southern comparison: cattle-centred lifeways, polished axes and ash-mound traditions show a distinct regional trajectory.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Retain one southern comparison: cattle-centred lifeways, polished axes and ash-mound traditions show a distinct regional trajectory.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that extra site names are supporting detail, not a core inventory.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: extra site names are supporting detail, not a core inventory.

ANSWER LINE: **Extra site names are supporting detail, not a core inventory.**

22

REGIONAL NEOLITHIC COMPARISON - WHAT VARIED AND WHAT CONVERGED

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Regional diversity persisted even as exchange networks widened.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Regional diversity persisted even as exchange networks widened.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Shared outcomes do not require a single origin.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Ecology shapes but does not mechanically determine culture.

ANSWER LINE: **Conclude that the Indian Neolithic was a connected mosaic: multiple pathways, partial convergence and persistent regionality.**

23

CHALCOLITHIC INDIA - DEFINITION, GEOGRAPHY AND CULTURAL SEQUENCE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Major concentrations include Rajasthan, Malwa, Maharashtra, the Ganga plains and eastern India.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Major concentrations include Rajasthan, Malwa, Maharashtra, the Ganga plains and eastern India.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Culture zones were networks of related material practice, not bounded political states.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Painted pottery is important but not exclusive.

ANSWER LINE: **Chalcolithic is not a uniform period.**

24

COPPER AND STONE TECHNOLOGY - ORE, SMELTING, ALLOYING AND SCARCITY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Inamgaon has evidence for copper extraction but copper remained scarce.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Control over ore and metal circulation could generate status without producing urban state power.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Inamgaon has evidence for copper extraction but copper remained scarce.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: ahar has copper sheet and slag supporting local metallurgy.

ANSWER LINE: **Ganeshwar yielded over a thousand copper objects but published reports do not provide direct furnace evidence for the early phase.**

25

GANESHWAR-JODHPURA - COPPER ZONE, CRAFT CENTRE AND HARAPPAN CONTACT — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Ore-zone communities may have supplied both rural neighbours and urban Harappans.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A small site can be regionally important through specialization.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Ore-zone communities may have supplied both rural neighbours and urban Harappans.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: the sequence shows movement from hunting with microliths toward extensive copper-working and wider interaction.

ANSWER LINE: **It is not a Harappan city.**

26

AHAR-BANAS CULTURE - RIVER VALLEYS, COPPER, FARMING AND SETTLEMENT DIVERSITY — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Compare Ahar, Gilund, Balathal and Pachamta to show internal settlement hierarchy and changing organization.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Balathal fauna was dominated by domesticates, especially cattle, and crops were stored in bins.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Compare Ahar, Gilund, Balathal and Pachamta to show internal settlement hierarchy and changing organization.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: shell and semi-precious materials indicate links to Gujarat and other zones.

ANSWER LINE: **White-painted black-and-red ware, copper use, mixed farming-herding and varied settlement sizes are major markers.**

27

KAYATHA CULTURE - EARLY MALWA SEQUENCE, WEALTH AND ABRUPT BREAK — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Kayatha is in the Malwa regional sequence.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The abrupt break could reflect conflict, ecological stress, mobility or other causes; evidence does not select one confidently.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Use Kayatha to discuss wealth concentration, cultural contact and the difficulty of explaining archaeological breaks.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Absence of grain remains in excavation is not proof of no farming.

ANSWER LINE: **Kayatha culture in western Madhya Pradesh is an early Chalcolithic phase with fine wheel-made pottery, microliths, copper objects and concentrated bead wealth.**

28

MALWA CULTURE - NAVDATOLI, ERAN, NAGDA AND DECCAN SPREAD — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Malwa pottery is rich in form and motif.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Malwa culture followed Ahar in parts of central India and spread into the Deccan.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Fire installations and decorated vessels have been interpreted ritually, but named-deity identifications are conjectural.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Malwa culture was a network spanning distinct local ecologies rather than a single homogeneous settlement system.

ANSWER LINE: **Navdatoli, Eran and Nagda are core Malwa sites.**

29

WESTERN DECCAN - SEQUENCE CAUTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Western Deccan - Sequence Caution is analysed by relating Western Deccan to Deccan Sequence, then testing the relationship through Sequence Caution and Sequence Caution.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use the region to explain non-linear change; do not memorise every ceramic phase for a general UPSC answer.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that western Deccan sequences show overlap and reorganisation across cultural labels.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: western Deccan sequences show overlap and reorganisation across cultural labels.

ANSWER LINE: **Western Deccan sequences show overlap and reorganisation across cultural labels.**

30

JORWE CULTURE - DISTRIBUTION, POTTERY AND SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Jorwe pottery has a red or bright-orange surface with black geometric painting.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Jorwe pottery has a red or bright-orange surface with black geometric painting.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Large centres coordinated craft, exchange or storage, but regional political integration remains uncertain.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: use settlement hierarchy to discuss regional integration without overstating state formation.

ANSWER LINE: **Inamgaon is a key Jorwe site.**

31

INAMGAON - SELECTIVE CASE USE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

In core answers, use it only to illustrate evidence-bound social differentiation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

In core answers, use it only to illustrate evidence-bound social differentiation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that inamgaon is a useful Deccan rural-lifeway case.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: inamgaon is a useful Deccan rural-lifeway case.

ANSWER LINE: **Inamgaon is a useful Deccan rural-lifeway case, but detailed household and rank reconstruction belongs to Optional Advanced depth.**

32

DECLINE AND TRANSFORMATION - LATE JORWE AND REGIONAL REORGANIZATION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Decline And Transformation - Late Jorwe And Regional Reorganization is analysed by relating Decline to Transformation - Late Jorwe, then testing the relationship through Regional Reorganization and Mains angle.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use 'decline/transformation' rather than a single dramatic collapse unless evidence warrants it.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Late levels show smaller huts, coarser pottery, reduced winter crops and greater reliance on hardy crops and wild resources.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Abandonment can mean mobility, reorganization or changed archaeological visibility rather than population disappearance.

ANSWER LINE: **Late Jorwe is not simply disappearance.**

33

OCP, COPPER HOARDS AND THE UPPER GANGA - ASSOCIATION WITHOUT ETHNIC LABELS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Hoards imply sophisticated metalworking but their users are difficult to identify.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Hoards imply sophisticated metalworking but their users are difficult to identify.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Metal skill does not require nomadism or urbanism.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: use OCP to demonstrate the difference between an artefact horizon and a historically named...

ANSWER LINE: **OCP and copper hoards overlap but are not identical distributions.**

34

NEOLITHIC, CHALCOLITHIC AND HARAPPAN - RELATIONSHIP AND DISTINCTIONS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Daimabad includes a late Harappan phase within a longer Deccan sequence.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Daimabad includes a late Harappan phase within a longer Deccan sequence.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Harappan demand may have stimulated rural resource specialization, but local agency remained important.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

These formations overlap chronologically and interacted materially, but differ in scale, settlement hierarchy, craft organization, writing and urban institutions.

ANSWER LINE: **Chalcolithic communities were not failed Harappans.**

35

INTERPRETATIONS AND SOURCE LIMITATIONS - ARCHAEOLOGICAL CULTURE IS NOT A PEOPLE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

New methods can change old interpretations.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

New methods can change old interpretations.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

These are analytical constructs and cannot independently establish ethnicity, language, polity or migration.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Absence of evidence can reflect preservation or research history rather than ancient absence.

ANSWER LINE: **Culture names organize data; they do not speak for ancient identity.**

36

TRANSITION, NOT A SINGLE REVOLUTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A technological label names an archaeological pattern; it does not by itself name a people or a destiny.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A technological label names an archaeological pattern; it does not by itself name a people or a destiny.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

In a Mains answer, use "mosaic", "regional" and "overlap" to avoid replacing foragers with an instant farmer category.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: mehrgarh, Kashmir, the Ganga valley and south India are comparison points, not stages of...

ANSWER LINE: **Mehrgarh, Kashmir, the Ganga valley and south India are comparison points, not stages of one national ladder.**

37

WHAT COUNTS AS DOMESTICATION EVIDENCE? — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, What Counts As Domestication Evidence? — [Core Prelims + Core Mains] is analysed by relating A seed, animal bone, tool or storage feature to It, then testing the relationship through Counts Domestication and Counts.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A technological label names an archaeological pattern; it does not by itself name a people or a destiny.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It can support an inference about cultivation, herding or food processing; it does not automatically settle domestic status or economic dependence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: it can support an inference about cultivation, herding or food processing.

ANSWER LINE: **A seed, animal bone, tool or storage feature is evidence only in context.**

38

REGION-SITE-MARKER TRIADS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Region-Site-Marker Triads is analysed by relating Mehrgarh--north-west--early to Burzahom--Kashmir--pit, then testing the relationship through Chirand--Bihar--long Neolithic-Chalcolithic and India--cattle.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A technological label names an archaeological pattern; it does not by itself name a people or a destiny.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Do not add every excavated site unless it changes the option or argument.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: south India--cattle/polished axes/ash mounds.

ANSWER LINE: **Use compact triads: Mehrgarh--north-west--early farming; Burzahom--Kashmir--pit dwellings/bone tools; Chirand--Bihar--long Neolithic-Chalcolithic sequence; south India--cattle/polished axes/ash mounds; Ahar-Gilund--Banas valley--Chalcolithic; Malwa--Navdatoli/Eran/Nagda; Jorwe--Maharashtra.**

39

FROM PRODUCTION TO SOCIAL CONSEQUENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, From Production To Social Consequence is analysed by relating A useful causal flow to From Production, then testing the relationship through Production Social and Production Social.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A technological label names an archaeological pattern; it does not by itself name a people or a destiny.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The word "possible" matters: storage or a larger house can be a clue, not proof of a fixed hierarchy.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: storage or a larger house can be a clue, not proof of a fixed...

ANSWER LINE: **A useful causal flow is ecology/domesticates - cultivation or herding - storage and settlement routines - surplus/craft/exchange - possible differentiation.**

40

CHALCOLITHIC IS RURAL AND REGIONAL, NOT FAILED HARAPPA — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A technological label names an archaeological pattern; it does not by itself name a people or a destiny.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A technological label names an archaeological pattern; it does not by itself name a people or a destiny.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Compare them with Harappan urbanism only to explain differences in scale, settlement and material organisation; never use a culture label as an ethnic identity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: it does not mean iron, automatic urbanism or a failed version of Harappa.

ANSWER LINE: **Chalcolithic means copper plus stone; it does not mean iron, automatic urbanism or a failed version of Harappa.**